app. Imagine that the quantum measurement has a 50 percent chance of triggering a gun that shoots a bullet into my head at close range, and a 50 percent chance of doing nothing. According to Many-Worlds, that implies the existence of two branches of the wave function, one of which contains a living version of me, the other of which contains a dead version.

Assume for purposes of the thought experiment we believe that life itself is a purely physical phenomenon, so we can set aside considerations of life after death. From my perspective, the branch on which the gun fired isn't one that any version of me ever gets to experience—my descendant in that world is dead. But my descendant continues on, unharmed, on the branch where the gun didn't fire. In some sense, then, "I" will live forever, even if I repeat this macabre procedure over and over again. One might go so far as to argue that I shouldn't object to actually going through this experiment (putting aside the rest of the world's feelings about me, I suppose)—in the branches where the gun fired "I" don't really exist, while in the single branch where it failed to fire time after time I'm perfectly healthy. (Tegmark's original point was less grandiose: he simply noted that an experimenter who survived a large number of trials would have good reason to accept the Everett picture.) This conclusion stands in stark contrast to a conventional stochastic formulation of quantum mechanics, where there is only one world, and I would have an increasingly tiny chance of being alive within it.

I do *not* recommend that you try such an experiment at home. In fact, the logic behind not caring about those branches in which you are killed is more than a little wonky.

Consider life in an old-fashioned, classical, single-universe picture. If you thought you lived in such a universe, would you mind if someone sneaked up behind you and shot you in the head so that you died instantly? (Again, setting aside the possibility that other people might be upset.) Most of us would not be in favor of that happening. But by the logic above, you really shouldn't "mind"—after all, once you're dead, there's no "you" to be upset about what happened.

The point being missed by this analysis is that we are upset *now*—while we are still very much alive and feeling—by the prospect of being dead in the future, especially if that future comes sooner rather than later. And that's a valid perspective; much of how we think about our current lives depends on a projection into the rest of our existence. Cutting that existence off is